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Bureaucrats' willingness to resist democratic backsliding: an experimental study in the Brazilian federal government

José Renato Fragoso Lobo[a], Maiara Marinho[b], Alketa Peci[a] and João V. Guedes-Neto[a]

[a]Brazilian School of Public and Business Administration, Getulio Vargas Foundation (FGV EBAPE), Rio de Janeiro, Brazil; [b]Centro de Ciências Jurídicas e Políticas, Universidade Federal do Estado do Rio de Janeiro (UNIRIO), Rio de Janeiro, Brazil

ABSTRACT

Amidst the surge of illiberal politics, understanding bureaucratic resistance is crucial for defending democratic norms. This paper investigates civil servants' predisposition to resist implementing undemocratic policies. We fielded two list experiments with 557 federal-level treasury attorneys in Brazil during the administration of a far-right president. We demonstrate a prevalent willingness to shirk responsibilities and, to a lesser extent, engage in sabotage when faced with antidemocratic directives. Resistance, especially through the sabotage of the government's plans, is more pronounced among non-political appointees who perceive their role as autonomous. These findings emphasize the central role of bureaucratic actors in preserving democratic integrity and call for strategic personnel policies to counter antidemocratic tendencies.

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Introduction

A growing number of studies have focused on understanding the rise of authoritarian politicians around the world (Grumbach 2023; Waldner and Lust 2018), their practices and adopted policies (Bauer and Becker 2020; Bermeo 2016; Bersch and Lotta 2024; Lotta, Tavares, and Story 2024; Sá e Silva 2020; 2022; Story, Lotta, and Tavares 2023), as well as strategies to contain democratic erosion resulting from actors within the public sector (Bauer 2024a; 2024b; Casarões, Silva do Monte, and Hernandez 2024; Grömping 2021; Guedes-Neto and Peters 2021; Lotta et al. 2023; Lotta, Silveira, and Fernandez 2023; Meyerrose 2020; Milhorance 2022; Trajber Waisbich 2024; Yesilkagit et al. 2024). Motivated by this latter point, our article seeks to answer the question: *Are bureaucrats willing to resist when confronted with policies representing democratic backsliding?*

Bureaucratic resistance in implementing public policies is not limited to cases of democratic erosion. Administrative discontinuity, for example, results from the various cycles of democratically elected governments, influencing the dynamics of public management (Aberbach and Rockman 1995; Bauer 2012; D'Araujo and Petek 2018). These changes can be so substantial as to interrupt projects that were previously

CONTACT João V. Guedes-Neto joao.neto@fgv.br Edifício Roberto Campos - R. Jorn. Orlando Dantas, 30 - Botafogo, Rio de Janeiro - RJ, 22231-010, Brazil[Q1]

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considered priorities (Vimieiro 2016). At the beginning of their term, the ruler faces an established administrative structure, whose response to their agenda may vary depending on the political and institutional context, potentially resulting in bureaucratic resistance (Bauer and Becker 2020). O'Leary (2010; 2017) coined the seminal term *guerrilla government* referring to cases when bureaucrats actively tried to block the implementation of public policies. Similarly, Brehm and Gates (1999) proposed the *working*, *shirking*, and *sabotage* triad to describe possible reactions of the bureaucracy when tasked with different political projects.

The imposition of changes can generate internal conflicts in government organizations, many of which result from the interaction between politicians and bureaucrats (Peters 2018), and the discrepancy in political preferences between them (Bach and Wegrich 2020). Bureaucracy plays a crucial role in this relationship, as depending on the composition of its workforce and the government's agenda, proposed changes can elicit reactions from public servants, sometimes resulting in obstacles to implementing new projects and limiting governance options and capacity (Bauer, Peters, and Pierre 2021).

As noted, bureaucratic responses to demands from superiors generally fall into three categories: working, shirking, and sabotage (Brehm and Gates 1999). From an organizational and societal perspective, compliance is the expected response, as it demonstrates alignment with the expectations of the democratically elected political leadership. However, as Brehm and Gates (1999) demonstrate, resistance is possible, expressed through shirking behaviours (for example, delaying deadlines, adding additional requirements) or sabotage (for example, confronting leadership directly, leaking information). These bureaucratic reactions have been corroborated by other studies, such as O'Leary (2010, 2017) and Hollibaugh, Miles, and Newswander (2020).

Although the theory of shirking and sabotage is often cited to highlight bureaucrats' inaction, both the original work and subsequent studies suggest that such cases are less common than compliance (Pierre and Peters 2017). In addition, the normative assumption of most studies in this field places shirking and sabotage as undesirable behaviours, thus expecting bureaucrats to work or to do at least *some* work when tasked with the implementation of a public policy in face of democratically elected political leaders.

We argue, however, that in contexts of democratic backsliding shirking and sabotage may become more frequent and, for some, the most normatively desirable responses (see Bauer 2024a). Following a bourgeoning literature on bureaucratic resistance (Bauer 2024a; 2024b; Casarões, Silva do Monte, and Hernandez 2024; Guedes-Neto and Peters 2021; Lotta et al. 2023; Lotta, Silveira, and Fernandez 2023; Milhorance 2022; Trajber Waisbich 2024; Yesilkagit et al. 2024), we contend that bureaucrats may use their expertise, knowledge, and autonomy to help block democratic backsliding processes. By shirking or even engaging in sabotage when assigned to illiberal projects, civil servants can modify public policies, slow down their implementation, or even block them (Guedes-Neto and Peters 2021).

Resistance comes at a cost. Bureaucrats face abusive supervision (Story, Lotta, and Tavares 2023) which severely affects their professional and personal well-being (Lotta, Tavares, and Story 2024). They may also be politically persecuted by the government or even struggle with different types of punishments, including dismissal. Muno and Briceño (2021) describe such cases during the Maduro administration in Venezuela, where the government sidelined "dissidents" through different strategies. In the face of

such costs, the decision to resist is not an easy one. We, therefore, focus on civil servants' willingness to bear the costs of resistance to act as veto points of illiberal politics.

The literature on democratic backsliding has focused on understanding the gradual erosion of democratic institutions under elected governments, in contrast to traditional democratic breakdowns such as military coups (Trajber Waisbich 2024). However, while part of the literature focuses on the definition and conceptualization of democratic backsliding (Bauer 2024a), another strand emphasizes institutional actors (Milhorance 2022; Trajber Waisbich 2024), and yet other concentrates on the individual actors themselves and their responses (Guedes-Neto and Peters 2021; Lotta, Silveira, and Fernandez 2023).

This last part of the literature has delved into understanding bureaucratic behaviour (Lotta, Silveira, and Fernandez 2023), with an emphasis on rational actions in response to the organizational context in which bureaucrats operate. It is within this discussion that our contribution is situated. The choice to focus on a unique group within the Brazilian bureaucracy – namely, treasury attorneys – allows for an in-depth analysis of resistance dynamics within a critical and influential federal agency. Moreover, our study seeks to contribute with a case study based on higher-quality data and greater external validity.

The most recent literature on bureaucratic behaviour has tended to adopt a more qualitative approach, focusing on describing forms of oppression (Lotta, Silveira, and Fernandez 2023) and engaging in theoretical debates on the justification of bureaucratic resistance (Bauer 2024a; 2024b). By contrast, the quantitative methodological design of this paper is more direct and aims to isolate the causal effect of political perceptions on bureaucrats' intention to shirk, resist and/or sabotage, following Guedes-Neto and Peters (2021) experimental approach.

Our study improves on Guedes-Neto and Peters (2021) in at least four ways. First, while their experiment used a convenience sample from two municipalities, we focus on the national level, where the democracy-authoritarianism divide is more evident, particularly under Bolsonaro's far-right presidency. Second, we survey treasury attorneys (PGFN), a group of federal civil servants hired through the merit system, with high autonomy and proximity to core federal policymaking, making exposure to illiberal policies more realistic. Third, our response rate (27%, $N = 557$) is substantially higher than the original study (2.5%, $N = 128$), and compares favourably to other recent surveys in Brazil's federal bureaucracy (see Lotta, Tavares, and Story 2024; Story, Lotta, and Tavares 2023), improving statistical power and representativeness. Fourth, while the original data was collected before Bolsonaro took office (November 2018–January 2019), ours was fielded in May 2022, after years of documented bureaucratic conflict under his administration (see Lotta et al. 2023; Sá e Silva 2020; 2022; Story, Lotta, and Tavares 2023), allowing for better informed responses.

Our findings causally demonstrate that an overwhelming majority of respondents exhibit a readiness to shirk responsibilities and, to a lesser degree, engage in sabotage against government initiatives perceived as undemocratic. Moreover, our analysis reveals a higher propensity for resistance among non-political appointee treasury attorneys, particularly those who perceive their role as possessing significant autonomy. These significant findings further validate the results of the growing literature on bureaucratic resistance (Bauer 2024a; 2024b; Casarões, Silva do Monte, and Hernandez 2024; Lotta et al. 2023; Lotta, Silveira, and Fernandez 2023; Milhorance 2022; Trajber Waisbich 2024; Yesilkagit et al. 2024) and underscore the necessity for strategic personnel

management policies and interventions aimed at thwarting antidemocratic endeavours that erode the integrity of public institutions.

A theory of bureaucratic resistance

New elections often bring leaders interested in promoting policy changes. Rulers must be attentive to bureaucracy to make sure their policy wishes are implemented (Bach and Wegrich 2020; Peters 2018). Within the government and aiming to avoid resistance to governmental agendas, elected officials must strategically assess the bureaucracy, negotiate with it, or attempt to control it (Aberbach and Rockman 1976). Bureaucrats, in turn, may use their autonomy and expertise to shape the policy process (Downs 1965) or even confront the expectations of elected officials (Gailmard and Patty 2007). Many times, elected officials and public employees engage in conflict over policy issues. In the United States, several studies considered clashes during the administrations of Dwight Eisenhower (Somers 1954), Richard Nixon (Aberbach and Rockman 1976), Ronald Reagan (Rockman 1993), and Donald Trump (Moynihan and Roberts 2021). Overall, acts of dissent may have various objectives, ranging from a response to unjust actions by a superior with their subordinates to actions aimed at transforming a government body, entity, or policy (Newswander 2015).

Public employees hold their own preferences and many play within and outside the rules to influence the policy process and its outcomes even when it means going against elected and non-elected superiors. Bureaucrats may set aside the Weberian model of the apolitical and duty-bound civil servant, adopting resistance behaviours such as shirking or sabotage when they perceive that the new government acts against their interests (Brehm and Gates 1999). These contrary attitudes to governmental guidelines are investigated in various works, as exemplified in the concept of "guerrilla government" (Hollibaugh, Miles, and Newswander 2020; O'Leary 2010, 2017).

Another way to understand the "principal-agent" relationship between bureaucrats and their superiors is in the triad proposed by Brehm and Gates (1999): working, shirking, and sabotage. By working, the public employees concentrate their efforts on task implementation. By shirking, they refrain from acting or are passive, hindering the completion of the assigned project and avoiding the task. By sabotaging, the bureaucrat is committed to undermining the objectives of public policy. In general, these forms of bureaucratic resistance are complementary actions and not mutually exclusive (O'Leary 2017; Schuster et al. 2022).

The actions of dissenters may have numerous motivations, ranging from the incongruence of public policy with the political preferences of the servant (Gailmard and Patty 2007) to the possibility of government actions causing harm to society (Hollibaugh, Miles, and Newswander 2020). They may even involve humanitarian or selfish and personal issues (O'Leary 2017). However, the literature findings indicate that the preference for working is generally higher than resistance behaviours (Pierre and Guy Peters 2017), also due to the intrinsic motivation of civil servants to deliver services to society (Perry 1997).

The risk of democratic backsliding adds a new flavour to bureaucratic resistance. The typical normative expectation is that bureaucrats will do at least some work when tasked with the implementation of a public policy (Pierre and Peters 2017). However, when

considering politicians and policies that attempt against the rule of law or democratic governance, bureaucratic resistance becomes an essential mechanism to break illiberal politics. In such cases, shirking and sabotage are the normatively desirable behaviour (Guedes-Neto and Peters 2021). This view aligns with James (2025), who argues that bureaucracies are not merely passive implementers of policy, but can actively promote or constrain democracy depending on their institutional norms, autonomy, and the pressures they face. Resistance may be essential to prevent democratic erosion.

Recent scholarship has consolidated the view that bureaucratic resistance – through shirking, sabotage, or other forms of dissent – is a normatively legitimate and empirically widespread response to illiberal political projects. Lotta et al. (2023) document how federal bureaucrats under Bolsonaro developed both formal and informal strategies of resistance, including selective implementation and internal advocacy, to defend democratic values. These acts are not isolated: Lotta, Silveira, and Fernandez (2023) show that bureaucrats actively react to institutional repression with a range of coping and contestation mechanisms. Milhorance (2022) further demonstrates that state agents played a key role in confronting systematic policy dismantling as a mode of democratic regression.

Transnational embeddedness also supports resistance: Trajber Waisbich (2024) finds that bureaucrats in internationalized sectors leveraged their global networks to counter domestic authoritarian shifts. Casarões, Silva do Monte, and Hernandez (2024) likewise describe how transnational democratic networks, including bureaucrats, mobilized to constrain autocratizing moves from within the state.

Together, these studies provide growing evidence that resistance is not only normatively desirable under democratic backsliding but also increasingly enacted across institutional and political contexts. James (2025) conceptualizes such behaviour as part of a broader continuum, in which civil servants may shift from democracy-enabling to democracy-promoting roles when facing authoritarian threats – underscoring the normative and institutional basis for bureaucratic resistance.

We, thus, expect that most public employees will be willing to oppose the guidelines of the ruler, acting in dissent (shirking or sabotaging), when faced with government projects that contradict democratic principles.

> H1a: Bureaucrats are more likely to shirk than to work when assigned to work on a project that restricts democratic rights, such as freedom of expression or freedom of the press.

> H1b: Bureaucrats are more likely to sabotage than to work when assigned to work on a project that restricts democratic rights, such as freedom of expression or freedom of the press.

Shirking involves employees neglecting their duties or not fully implementing policies, which can be done more discreetly and with lower chances of detection or reprisal compared to sabotage, where employees actively undermine or disrupt government projects (Brehm and Gates 1999). Since sabotage entails more overt actions that could lead to disciplinary measures, legal consequences, or even loss of employment, individuals may be more cautious about engaging in such behaviour.

There are accounts of different types of reprisals for bureaucratic dissent, including sidelining (Muno and Briceño 2021) and political persecution (Moynihan and Roberts 2021). In Brazil, civil servants enjoy substantive protections – higher than many

democratic countries (Dahlström, Lapuente, and Teorell 2012). This makes firing very unlikely even during illiberal administrations, as is the case of Jair Bolsonaro's presidency. Still, this illiberal politician and his allies have engaged in abusive practices to reprehend bureaucrats who did not comply with their agenda (Story, Lotta, and Tavares 2023). Those engaging in open resistance through sabotage are arguably more likely to suffer than those who opt to shirk.

Guedes-Neto and Peters (2021) suggest that given the heightened risks associated with sabotage, individuals may be more inclined to opt for shirking as a safer means of resistance. Therefore, while both shirking and sabotage serve as forms of dissent against anti-democratic policies, the expectation is that shirking will be more prevalent among public employees due to its lower risk profile. This distinction highlights the nuanced decision-making processes involved in bureaucratic resistance and underscores the importance of understanding the incentives and disincentives that shape such behaviour.

H1c: Bureaucrats are more likely to shirk than to sabotage when assigned to work on a project that restricts political freedoms, such as freedom of expression or freedom of the press.

Conditional resistance

Politicians try to control the bureaucracy. For instance, President Nixon, upon realizing he lacked support from the bureaucracy, began exerting strong control over appointments of agency personnel, opting for individuals strongly committed to partisan ideals (Aberbach and Rockman 1995). A similar tactic was employed by President Reagan, who, upon perceiving the co-optation of the civil service by Democrats, chose to exert greater control, making the bureaucracy more responsive (Rockman 1993). More recently, Donald Trump created the Schedule F position to undermine the merit system by recruiting more political allies through patronage appointments (Moynihan 2022).

In Brazil, the promulgation of the Federal Constitution of 1988 created a strengthened bureaucracy, where access to career public positions became impersonal and universal through public competitions, with progression rules based on meritocracy (Olivieri 2007). Although this merit-based system is common in the democratic world, Dahlström, Lapuente, and Teorell (2012) demonstrate that the protections of the Brazilian public service are even greater than those of other countries, such as the United States and the United Kingdom.

This Federal Constitution aimed at addressing a major concern derived from the third wave of democratization: the risk that powerful leaders would impose setbacks in the democratization process, pushing new democracies back to their authoritarian past. This means that, as it happened in other Latin American countries, the new Brazilian model included multiple veto points to inhibit drastic policy. This includes, for example, the multiparty, bicameral model that obliges elected officials to engage in coalition presidentialism to govern (Pereira et al. 2017).

In this system of government, the merit-based bureaucracy gained greater prominence due to its technical capacity, stability, and being fundamental for the implementation of public policies independently from political control (Abrucio and Loureiro 2018; Praça, Odilla, and Guedes-Neto 2022). Naturally, elected officials can still appoint part of the federal bureaucracy (Praça, Odilla, and Guedes-Neto 2022). These commissioned

positions (in Portuguese, *cargos comissionados*) can be filled by career civil servants and outsiders to their workforce, through political appointments (Cavalcante and Carvalho 2017; Praça, Odilla, and Guedes-Neto 2022).

These positions often come with supervisory and managerial duties, and may function as one of the few opportunities to achieve career growth among career bureaucrats, even though they are temporary. Still, they consist of a small portion of all public employees, who are mostly recruited through the merit system and retain strong Weberian-style job stability (Schuster et al. 2022). This hybrid model of politically-appointed career bureaucrats, while it may strengthen the bureaucracy, can also function as a form of control (Cavalcante, Lotta, and Oliveira 2018; Panizza, Peters, and Larraburu 2019, 2022).

Panizza, Peters, and Larraburu (2019, 2022) describe two supplementary characteristics for the selection of commission appointees: technical capacity and political proximity, which do not need to be combined. There are cases where the technical capacity of an agency is not sufficient for the implementation of a public policy and requires the appointment of an outsider technician. In other cases, the lack of cooperation from the agency motivates the elected politician to appoint someone of their political trust to manage the implementation of projects relevant to their agenda (see also Guedes-Neto 2022; Praça, Odilla, and Guedes-Neto 2022). In fact, political appointees from President Bolsonaro attempted to assure control and compliance through illiberal means, including abusive supervisory practices (Lotta et al. 2023; Sá e Silva 2020; Story, Lotta, and Tavares 2023).

To be sure, while the president has the authority to remove someone from a commissioned position, this does not imply that the bureaucrat will lose her job. Once removed, they will return to their original functions within the federal bureaucracy, for most of the positions. This represents some financial loss and the potential reduction in the employee's status and power. However, this form of punishment is not equivalent to what may happen in authoritarian systems such as Venezuela (Muno and Briceño 2021).

Assuming, then, that the free appointment and dismissal in commissioned positions are a form of bureaucracy control, we propose that career servants occupying commissioned positions will have a lower propensity to resist the implementation of projects that restrict democratic rights than those who do not hold commissioned positions or perform commissioned functions.

> H2: Bureaucrats are less likely to resist projects that restrict political rights when they hold a commissioned position, compared to those who do not hold a commissioned position.

The context of excessive clientelist relations motivated calls for the separation between politics and the administration (Wilson 1889) and the development of a rational-bureaucratic civil service (Weber 2011) capable of impartially implementing public policies (see also Abrucio and Loureiro 2018). In the United States, the Pendleton Act marked a transition to the merit system (Hoogenboom 1959) – a path followed by several (if not most) countries in the democratic world (see, e.g. Wahrlich 1976) and, to a certain extent, undemocratic as well (Tsao and Worthley 1995).

In the merit system, political and administrative activities complement each other. Overall, administrative activities are carried out by the bureaucracy, characterized by its technical-scientific approach (Abrucio and Loureiro 2018; Overeem 2005). Still, bureaucrats' discretionary power allows them to play a political role (Peters 2018) as

long as it is within expected ethical standards (Hollibaugh, Miles, and Newswander 2020). This separation transformed modern bureaucracies into central actors in the process of formulating and implementing public policies (Abrucio and Loureiro 2018; Bauer, Peters, and Pierre 2021), no longer being passive and subordinate structures (Bauer, Peters, and Pierre 2021).

In this balance between politics and administration, the analysis of this relationship revolves around a fundamental question of what level of autonomy is necessary for the establishment of good governance (Bach and Wegrich 2020). Although subject to norms, autonomy allows bureaucrats to interpret them, granting them political powers that influence the design of public policies (Freire, Viana, and Palotti 2015).

The problem with the assumption of autonomy is that it is based on the idea of a bureaucrat in the Weberian tradition, without personal or political preferences, dedicated only to the fulfilment of norms. Peters (2018) challenges this assumption, arguing that the depoliticization of bureaucracy allows politics to continue to occur, albeit without the scrutiny received by partisan politics. The motivations of public employees continue to bias their actions, mainly through the tools allowed by their high expertise and autonomy in decision-making (Downs 1967). One possible action is precisely democratic resistance.

With their classic activities enhanced by the growth of state functions, the autonomy of the civil service strengthened the role of bureaucracy in public administration, giving bureaucrats greater resistance power (Bach and Wegrich 2020). Given the above, it is understood that a bureaucracy endowed with greater autonomy in carrying out its activities will have a greater willingness to disagree with the government and adopt a resistant stance when it understands that the proposed project represents a democratic setback.

H3: Bureaucrats are more likely to resist projects that restrict political rights compared to projects that do not when they have greater autonomy to develop their tasks.

Guedes-Neto and Peters (2021) contend that civil servants who perceive lower remuneration in the public sector than they would earn in the private sector are more disloyal to the government – or, at least, more predisposed to be disloyal if needed. There are at least two explanations for this expectation, one related to the costs of resistance and the other to the intrinsic motivation of being in the public sector.

In addition to the constitutionally guaranteed stability, the remuneration and benefits obtained in the public service can exceed those offered in the market (Belluzzo, Anuatti-Neto, and Pazello 2005; Hasnain et al. 2021; World Bank 2022). This is even more prevalent in the federal administration than in the subnational entities studied by Guedes-Neto and Peters (2021). Thus, there is a financial cost to democratic resistance, as it could lead to loss of employment (see, for example, Muno and Briceño 2021). Therefore, those with lower costs (i.e. those who believe they would earn a higher salary in the private sector) would be more willing to resist.

In addition to that, the intrinsic motivation that is prevalent in the civil service (Perry 1997) may lead civil servants to choose to earn a lower remuneration in the public service compared to the earning potential of the private sector because they believe in the importance of the public sector for society (Guedes-Neto and Peters 2021). We posit that, at least to a certain extent, believing that one's salary would be higher in the private

sector may function as a proxy for high public service motivation. This preference motivates public employees to protect democratic institutions even more strongly, meaning that they would be more likely to resist in cases of democratic erosion. We hypothesize that:

> H4: Bureaucrats are more likely to resist projects that restrict political rights compared to projects that do not when they believe that the salary in the private sector is higher than in the public sector.

Case study: the Brazilian attorney general's office of the treasury

We focus on treasury attorneys working at the Brazilian Attorney General's Office of the Treasury (PGFN). The PGFN is present in all Brazilian states and the Federal District, and its workforce consists of 2,086 career members of the National Treasury Attorney, 1,577 administrative servants, 1,010 interns, and 1,382 outsourced workers (PGFN 2023).

This office is a federal agency with dual subordination: it is administratively linked to the Ministry of Economy (in Portuguese, Ministério da Fazenda or MF) and is technically and legally subordinate to the Office of the Attorney General of the Union (in Portuguese, Advocacia-Geral da União, or AGU). The PGFN's responsibilities include determining the liquidity and certainty of the Union's tax debt and its registration for collection purposes, representing the Union in the enforcement of its tax debt and fiscal matters, and providing legal advice to the MF (Brazil 1993; 1988 and 1967).

The PGFN's participates in the formulation of public policies, international agreements, and external financial contracts, and provides legal advice on administrative acts and contracts of interest to the Ministry of Economy (PGFN, 2023). Although PGFN does not deal directly with individual freedoms in the same way as other public agencies such as the Federal Police or the Brazilian Intelligence Agency, it remains a valid case for study, as its activities contribute to legal certainty, cost-effectiveness, corruption prevention, and fiscal responsibility, enhancing the quality of public services for citizens.

In 2019, with the inauguration of President Jair Bolsonaro, the PGFN expanded its activities (BRASIL 2019). The new administration merged economic-related ministries into a single agency – the Ministry of Economy (ME). Treasury attorneys took over the legal consultancy roles of the dissolved ministries integrated into the ME, such as the Ministry of Planning, Development, and Management, the Ministry of Labour, and the Ministry of Industry, Foreign Trade, and Services. Previously, this advisory role was the responsibility of the AGU. The decision to merge the ministerial portfolio was revoked with the inauguration of President Lula da Silva in January 2023.

Projects, policies, and programmes led by the ME necessarily undergo legal analysis by the PGFN, e.g. policies to reduce the economic impact of the Covid-19 pandemic, measures to reduce unemployment, and proposals for new and amended regulations. Recently, the list projects evaluated by treasury attorneys included the administrative reform, tax reform, and social security reform. Similarly, the PGFN plays a crucial role in federal privatization processes, having participated in the privatization of pre-salt oil reserves, Eletrobrás, TAG – Associated Gas Transporter, BR Distribuidora and Liquigás, Brazilian Reinsurance Institute (IRB), Espírito Santo Dock Company, Petrobras oil fields, and others.

If incumbents have an interest in favouring an economic group that supports them, they may impose the issuance of a PGFN opinion defending the constitutionality of measures that are, in fact, illegal. Examples include actions aimed at granting tax exemptions or offering overly favourable instalment plans to favour economic sectors with close ties to the presidency. One may also intervene in mechanisms like tax settlements to benefit one's allies or prevent the PGFN from implementing its open debt system, which discloses debtors to the public, considering that transparency is not a hallmark of undemocratic governments. Additionally, an incumbent could enforce subpar performance in collecting employment social benefits, thereby enabling greater tax evasion by employers.

Besides the reorganizing of the ministerial portfolio, the Bolsonaro administration also enacted a federal ordinance (Decree No. 9,794 on May 14, 2019) making the president's chief of staff responsible for scrutinizing all candidates for high-level political appointments (the commissioned positions, or *cargos comissionados*). The Integrated Nomination and Consultation System (SINC) was designed to register, analyze, and control these appointments (BRASIL 2019). Previously, the responsibility for appointing treasury attorneys to commissioned positions rested solely with the PGFN's attorney general. Despite repeated efforts by the PGFN to assert its preferences, the Chief of Staff's Office maintained the final approval authority, even disapproving some appointments.

The PGFN's central role in Brazil's economic policy makes it an analytically appropriate agency to study bureaucratic behaviour under conditions of democratic stress. While its institutional characteristics may set its resistance dynamics apart from those of other federal agencies, the PGFN offers a valuable perspective on the actions of a highly professionalized and technically skilled segment of the civil service with direct influence over core economic policymaking. Its proximity to the executive decision-making centre increases the likelihood of exposure to political pressures – especially during periods of institutional weakening. As James (2025) highlights, resistance is more likely – and more consequential – within professionalized bureaucracies embedded in the policy core, especially when their institutional norms conflict with authoritarian objectives.

This represents a key improvement over Guedes-Neto and Peters (2021), whose experiment was fielded at the subnational level in two Brazilian municipalities. Although the democracy-authoritarianism divide exists at lower levels of government (Grumbach 2023; Leonard 2024), it was far more salient at the national level during the administration of far-right President Jair Bolsonaro. Studying PGFN attorneys thus enables us to assess bureaucratic resistance in a setting where illiberal pressures were more centralized, visible, and consequential. Still, we recognize that findings from this agency may not be fully generalizable to the broader federal bureaucracy.

Empirical design

Survey design

To causally estimate the likelihood of resistance, we employ a survey experiment with a convenience sample of treasury attorneys. We adapted two experiments conducted by Guedes-Neto and Peters (2021) for the PGFN's context. We largely mirrored the original

online questionnaire and sent it to the email addresses of all PGFN's treasury attorneys. After passing through two eligibility questions – age (to prevent those aged below 18 years old) and whether they were treasury attorneys at PGFN (to prevent other bureaucrats to advance) – we asked questions about individual and organizational characteristics.

Subsequently, respondents passed through two list experiments, one assessing the shirking strategy and the other focused on sabotage. Following the original study, we adopted the list experiment methodology to avoid contamination of the data by social desirability bias (Guedes-Neto and Peters 2021). When researching sensitive topics, there is always the risk that the respondent will provide responses that are desirable from a normative point of view, even if they do not reflect their real thoughts (Peters and Guedes-Neto 2020; Gonzalez-Ocantos et al. 2012).

In list experiments, respondents are randomly assigned to one of two groups: control and treatment. The control group reads a vignette and is presented with four scenarios. After reading, they are asked how many scenarios they would choose according to the question. Note: They do not indicate which scenarios they would select; only the number of scenarios. The treatment group is exposed to a very similar condition, with the only difference being the addition of a fifth item to the list. Thus, we can compare the average response of the control group (four items) and the treatment group (five items), with the difference between them being the proportion of respondents who would select the fifth item.

Therefore, in the first list (shirking), the respondent was asked to read the following text:

> The following scenarios are common in public organizations around the world. There is evidence that some of these scenarios demotivate public servants, leading them to dedicate less effort than they would to other activities. For example, they may try to assign another colleague to perform these tasks, may do them partially, miss deadlines, or not perform them.

For the control group, we presented four scenarios that demotivate public servants, and afterward, we asked how many of these scenarios would lead the bureaucrat to shirk.

> A public servant was assigned to work on a project that …
>
> (a) Is very similar to all the other projects they have always worked on
> (b) Favours only their own political group
> (c) Is completely new to them, requiring training and additional effort
> (d) Creates a political advantage for groups they are against

For the treatment group, we presented these four scenarios, plus a fifth item: "*Restricts the political rights of citizens, for example, their freedom of expression or freedom of the press.*"

While PGFN treasury attorneys may not typically handle cases directly influencing freedoms of expression and the press, their work could intersect with these issues. They might deal with tax exemptions, tax collection, or civil debt cases involving media organizations such as newspapers or TV stations. This makes it more likely for treasury attorneys to encounter such situations compared to the local bureaucrats surveyed in Guedes-Neto and Peters (2021). Furthermore, illiberal policies originating

from the president – in topics other than freedom of expression and of the press – are far more likely to impact federal bureaucrats, like treasury attorneys, than local bureaucrats.

Our decision to use a generic vignette that includes a case not typically related to the PGFN's main functions was intentional. This approach was designed to avoid priming responses based on specific cases that treasury attorneys have handled in the past. By using a generic case that objectively represents illiberal policies, we aimed to create a proxy for various instances when treasury attorneys might encounter policies they consider illiberal. This abstraction helps prevent biased responses and ensures that the vignette has a consistent impact on respondents handling different tasks. Therefore, while the specific scenario in our vignette may seem abstract, it serves as a useful proxy for the types of illiberal policies that treasury attorneys might face.

The same control and treatment groups, aiming to analyze the possibility of sabotage, were then confronted with the following situation:

> Now, consider the possibility of sabotage. A common reaction in different public agencies is that some public servants decide to work against a project they have been assigned to. In other words, instead of implementing it, they decide to do everything they can to prevent the project from moving forward.

We presented the same scenarios from the shirking list, and respondents were asked how many of them would lead a standard public servant to work against the project instead of implementing it: "*In your opinion, how many of the previous scenarios would lead a standard public servant to work against the project instead of implementing it? Please only respond with the number of scenarios.*" The possible responses for both experiment lists ranged from 0 to 4 for the control group and from 0 to 5 for the treatment group. This approach ensures that respondents consider the scenarios from the perspective of a standard public servant, rather than reflecting solely on their own experiences. By framing the question this way, we aim to reduce social desirability bias, which is prevalent in sensitive cases such as shirking and sabotage (Peters and Guedes-Neto 2020).

For the outcome, the difference between the averages of the control and treatment groups is relevant, representing the share of those who opted for the fifth statement, present only in the treatment group. By asking the number of situations and not which situations "a public servant" (not necessarily the respondent) would practice, we reduced the impact of social desirability bias even more, as respondents were not required to admit to performing a specific action contrary to norms, such as fleeing or sabotaging (Peters and Guedes-Neto 2020).

Data collection

Although the questionnaire was sent to all PFGN's treasury attorneys in the country via email, no systematic sampling technique was adopted, characterizing our approach as convenience and accessibility sampling. Given that this is a hard-to-reach population, and that the experimental method allows the use of convenience sampling, the study maintains its empirical validity. Data collection was carried out through the Qualtrics platform, ensuring anonymity and randomization between groups. The survey was conducted over four days in May 2022. We are not aware of any major political event taking place during the data collection process.

We obtained formal authorization from the then General Treasury Attorney (Subprocuradora-Geral da PGFN) to access institutional email addresses for all active attorneys at the PGFN, allowing us to distribute the survey securely and directly within the agency. A total of 2,197 invitations were sent; 67 emails bounced due to delivery errors, resulting in 2,130 valid contacts. In May 2022, the PGFN had 2,086 active attorneys. The slight discrepancy between valid emails and the number of attorneys is explained by additional institutional accounts associated with leadership positions, often held or managed by administrative staff. These cases were filtered through eligibility questions on age and professional status, ensuring the final sample included only PGFN treasury attorneys.

Beyond its internal validity, our approach also offers a significant improvement over previous studies in terms of timing. Guedes-Neto and Peters (2021) fielded their experiment between November 2018 and January 2019, during the transition period following Bolsonaro's election. At that moment, civil servants had limited information about the administration's likely trajectory. In contrast, our survey was conducted in May 2022 – at the end of Bolsonaro's term – after years of repeated institutional confrontations, policy dismantling, and democratic erosion. This timing allowed respondents to draw on concrete experiences rather than hypothetical scenarios. Recent studies on the relationship between Bolsonaro's government and the federal bureaucracy (Lotta et al., 2023; Sá e Silva 2020; 2022; Story, Lotta, and Tavares 2023) confirm that bureaucrats underwent a learning process during this period, which likely resulted in more informed, realistic, and credible responses to our survey.

The response rate was notably high: 660 individuals (31% of successfully delivered emails) answered the questionnaire. After excluding incomplete responses, missing data, and ineligible participants, the final analyzed sample comprised 557 treasury attorneys – representing approximately 27% of the target population of 2,086. This rate is over ten times higher than that obtained by Guedes-Neto and Peters (2021), whose municipal-level study reached only 128 respondents (a 2.5% response rate). Low response rates are common in surveys with bureaucrats. For instance, Lotta, Tavares, and Story (2024) surveyed 236 civil servants at IBGE, which employed 4,022 people (5.9% response rate), and later surveyed 255 staff members at the Ministry of Environment, where the workforce totalled 3,030 (8.4% response rate) (Story, Lotta, and Tavares 2023). In contrast, our 27% response rate offers stronger statistical power and enhances the likelihood that the results reflect the broader perceptions within the selected agency. It also enables more robust analysis of heterogeneous treatment effects.

Modelling

For data analysis, we employed an ordinary least squares (OLS) estimation strategy to calculate the average treatment effects (ATE). In the absence of control variables, this is identical to a two-tailed t-test – a difference-in-means estimator. To identify the independent variable, we used a dummy variable, in which 1 indicates treatment and 0 control. This parsimonious test is widely adopted in the literature (see, e.g. Gonzalez-Ocantos et al. 2012; Kuklinski, Kobb, and Gilens 1997).

Imai (2011; see also Blair and Imai 2012) argues that the difference-in-means estimator may be inefficient, especially in measuring the treatment effects on different subsamples (the heterogeneous treatment effects, or HTE). For this reason, we employ

different techniques in addition to the basic ordinary least squares model (linear model, or LM), namely, LM with covariates, the Maximum Likelihood (ML) estimation with the Expectation-Maximization algorithm, and Non-linear Least Squares (NLS) estimation with the two-step procedure. These are helpful to improve efficiency in the estimation of the ATE, as well as when estimating the HTE. This includes covariates such as holding a commissioned position (supervision) (H2) and perception of private sector salary (H4).

Findings

In Appendix 1, we present the covariates' descriptive statistics (Appendix 1 Table 1) and the balance tests (Appendix 1 Table 2). The balance test confirms that our randomization process adequately led to control and treatment groups that are indiscernible based on the characteristics mapped through our survey questions. We can, thus, argue that any treatment effects identified in our study are the outcome of our experiment interventions, rather than pre-treatment differences across samples.

The main results are described in Table 1, where the estimated proportion represents the share of respondents who included the fifth item among their chosen items. In all cases, the average treatment effect is high and statistically significant. Consider, first, the shirking experiment. In the LM (equivalent to a difference-in-means approach), we estimate that 58.82% of the respondents are willing to shirk if assigned to implement an undemocratic policy. The proportion of shirkers grows with other estimation strategies, reaching 68.98% in the most robust statistical test (see Imai 2011). This finding supports H1a.

These effects are lower than those obtained by Guedes-Neto and Peters (2021), who identified a willingness to shirk among 84% of their respondents using the difference-of-means approach. Again, our sample is likely more representative of the selected agency and more exposed to policies that affect democratic governance. Furthermore, while our ATE are lower, they are still substantively high, demonstrating that the majority of respondents are willing to resist.

Our sabotage experiment also yielded a lower predisposition to resist than what Guedes-Neto and Peters (2021) found. Their original experiment found an ATE of 104% of the respondents, meaning also that the experiment generated some spill-over effect. In other words, not only all respondents pick the fifth item, but also an additional 4% ended up picking another item once they reflected on the possibility of democratic backsliding. Our results are more modest, yet substantively high. Our comparable estimation of difference-in-means shows an ATE of 56.99%. This is very

Table 1. Average treatment effects using different estimation strategies.

	Shirking		Sabotage	
	Est. Proportion	Conf. Interval	Est. Proportion	Conf. Interval
LM	0.5882*	0.4325–0.7439	0.5699*	0.3995–0.7404
LM with controls	0.5902*	0.4332–0.7473	0.5626*	0.3920–0.7332
MLE with controls	0.6898*	0.4909–0.8887	0.5327*	0.3829–0.6826
NLS with controls	–	–	0.5578*	0.3923–0.7232

Note**:** Confidence intervals at 95%. * $p < 0.05$. The NLS model with controls for the shirking experiment did not converge. $N = 557$.

similar to all other coefficients, which are never below 53.27% (MLE with controls). This supports H1b.

Another difference from the original study rests on the comparison between the willingness to shirk and sabotage. Guedes-Neto and Peters (2021) find that bureaucrats are more likely to sabotage than to shirk. Our substantive results show that the estimated proportion of shirkers is higher than that of saboteurs; however, if we consider the confidence intervals, shirking and sabotage become indiscernible. In other words, we do not have robust statistical data to support H1c, even though this is a possible outcome if we, for example, rely on a larger dataset.

The most robust statistical techniques (i.e. MLE and NLS) are adequate for estimating the ATE, but they were designed to measure heterogeneous treatment effects (Blair and Imai 2012; Imai 2011). Since only the MLE model converged for both experiments, we adopted this modelling strategy to calculate the HTE. We present the results in Table 2. We are specifically interested in dividing the sample in three different ways.

The first regards whether treasury attorneys held a commissioned position. Our results confirm that commissioned treasury attorneys will be less likely to resist than others (H2). For both shirking and sabotage, the ATE of commissioned is lower than that of non-commissioned treasury attorneys. Even though the difference in both proportions is high (15.8 p.p. for shirking and 39.7 p.p. for sabotage), only the latter difference is statistically significant.[1]

Second, we consider respondents' perceived autonomy. In the survey, we asked treasury attorneys how much autonomy they have when making decisions in their work (0–10 scale). In the data, we identified a natural cut-off point at 7, with most respondents claiming to have a high degree of autonomy. We, then, split the sample into two: high (7–10) and low (0–6) autonomy. Again, the comparison of ATEs follows the expected direction (H3), with a higher likelihood of resistance of 30.0 p.p. for shirking and 29.8 p.p. for sabotage for those with high autonomy. As it happened for the previous test, only the sabotage experiment yields a statistically significant difference.

Finally, we asked respondents to reflect on their salary relative to possible earnings in the private sector. They were presented with three choices: a higher salary in the private sector, the same salary, or their current salary in government being higher than a possible job elsewhere. We split the sample into two: salary in the private sector is higher vs. not higher (either lower or the same). Our tests found no discernible differences across

Table 2. Heterogeneous treatment effects.

	Shirking		Sabotage	
	Estimate	Conf. Interval	Estimate	Conf. Interval
Commissioned	0.569	1.173 – (−0.036)	0.232	0.631 – (0.166)
Non-Commissioned	0.727	0.917–0.537	0.630	0.776–0.483
Difference	−0.158	0.486 – (−0.802)	−0.397^	0.029 – (−0.823)
High Autonomy	0.774	1.001–0.543	0.620	0.796–0.444
Low Autonomy	0.474	0.804–0.144	0.322	0.562–0.081
Difference	0.300	0.688 – (−0.087)	0.298*	0.589–0.007
Private is Higher	0.649	0.896–0.402	0.573	0.789–0.357
Private is Not Higher	0.732	1.069–0.396	0.491	0.683–0.299
Difference	−0.084	0.352 – (−0.519)	0.081	0.361 – (−0.198)

Note: Maximum Likelihood (ML) estimation with the Expectation-Maximization algorithm. Confidence intervals at 95%. *$p < 0.05$; ^$p < 0.10$. $N = 557$.

groups. The changes in the shirking and sabotage experiments lead to opposite directions. Still, they are not statistically significant and reject H4.

Conclusion

This study asks whether the Brazilian federal bureaucrats, when faced with projects that represent democratic backsliding, work to implement them, shirk, or sabotage them. This effort follows a bourgeoning literature dedicated to understanding bureaucratic resistance in Brazil, including Guedes-Neto and Peters (2021), Milhorance (2022), Lotta et al. (2023), Lotta, Silveira, and Fernandez (2023), Bersch and Lotta (2024), Casarões, do Monte, and Hernandez (2024), and Trajber Waisbich (2024).

Our experimental design, initially pre-tested by Guedes-Neto and Peters (2021) with a small sample of local-level public employees, has been significantly refined in our study. By focusing on a more representative sample of treasury attorneys, our research provides a deeper understanding of bureaucratic resistance in a more realistic scenario. The timing of our data collection, during the latter part of Jair Bolsonaro's presidency, allowed respondents to offer more accurate answers based on their experiences with democratic backsliding. This approach not only enhances the robustness of our statistical tests but also underscores the importance of confirmatory studies in validating and strengthening existing theoretical frameworks on bureaucratic behaviour and democratic erosion.

Additionally, while our study measures attitudes (willingness to resist), this willingness indicates that bureaucrats face at least some discomfort when confronted with undemocratic policies. Although actual behaviour may be more costly than expressing attitudes in a survey, the willingness to resist is a significant indicator of potential resistance. This approach aligns with the methodology used in similar studies and provides valuable insights into the mindset of federal civil servants in Brazil.

The results deepen the discussion about the role of bureaucracy in the face of populist governments (see Bauer 2024a; 2024b; Bauer, Peters, and Pierre 2021; Yesilkagit et al. 2024) because, while statistically confirming and reinforcing most of the findings found by Guedes-Neto and Peters (2021), they advance toward an even more generalizable understanding of the behaviour of a federal-level bureaucracy (see also Lotta, Silveira, and Fernandez, 2023). Following H1a and H1b, we confirm that a substantive majority of civil servants are willing to resist undemocratic policies through shirking and sabotage – terms originally coined by Brehm and Gates (1999) to speak of dissent in times of democratic normality. This reinforces James' (2025) call to recognize bureaucrats not only as agents of policy implementation but as frontline actors in the defense of democratic governance, especially when institutional norms and protections are still intact.

Regarding H1c, our results are partially different from those offered by Guedes-Neto and Peters (2021). The original study identified an average treatment effect (ATE) of 104% for sabotage. This meant that when respondents saw the illiberal item in the list experiment, they were triggered to choose more items that were not chosen in the control condition. This also meant that the ATE of sabotage was greater than that of shirking. Our improved sample resulted in an ATE that is below 100% – therefore fixing the spill-over effect problem – and shows that intent to sabotage is not greater than to shirk. Considering the costs of both reactions, our results seem more plausible and support our theoretical expectations.

We further show that proximity to political power through appointments and limited autonomy reduce public employees' willingness to resist. While the Wilsonian tradition has recommended the separation between politics and administration (see Wilson 1889), our results suggest that even the insulated, merit-based bureaucracy is still a target of politicians and is willing to use its own politicization to resist (see also Peters 2018). Our findings reinforce the necessity to invest in the development of a cadre of bureaucrats who are capable of discerning when to resist the orders of elected authorities.

The evidence suggests that the PGFN, regardless of being considered a reasonably insulated mid-level bureaucracy, is overwhelmingly willing to resist when faced with illiberal policies. This intention involves departing from the neutrality inherent in the Weberian model, a characteristic that has long been attributed to it (Hollibaugh, Miles, and Newswander 2020), and either adhering to or rejecting government and ruler directives.

Political appointments are an important mean of bureaucratic control (see also Panizza, Peters, and Larraburu 2019; 2022). In some cases, it has been used to engage in political persecution and abusive supervisory practices (Lotta, Tavares, and Story 2024; Moynihan 2022; Moynihan and Roberts 2021; Story, Lotta, and Tavares 2023). This phenomenon explains the willingness to resist anti-democratic projects being considerably higher among those who do not supervise people when compared to those who supervise and hold political positions. Since supervisors are career civil servants and enjoy stability (even in case they lose their commissioned status), this situation may arise due to the closer proximity of commissioned officials to elected officials (Aberbach and Rockman 1995).

The bureaucracy's willingness to resist does not necessarily lead to the weakening of characteristics such as impartiality, responsibility, and professionalism (Bauer 2024a; 2024b; Bauer, Peters, and Pierre 2021). It is an expression that a share of public employees is dedicated to protecting democracy.

This is evident when, even among the leadership group, there is still a slight tendency to sabotage on the part of respondents. This predisposition may stem from the fact that, even in positions and functions subject to free appointment and dismissal, in the PGFN, political interference is not forceful (Cagni 2020). This finding strengthens the premise that political influence on bureaucracy also varies according to the institutional history of the organization (Lopez and Silva 2019).

Confirming expectations, we observed the association of public service autonomy, as well as the professionalization of its workforce, with greater resistance from bureaucrats. The attributes of PGFN members, such as high education levels and a high sense of autonomy, contribute to the Office of the Treasury's resistance to projects that undermine democracy, given its greater independence in its actions. However, this situation also shows that the professionalization of the bureaucracy, a fundamental characteristic of the Weberian bureaucratic model, while defining this model, can also be the reason for its decay, as it contributes to the formation of a more independent and possibly more reactive bureaucratic body to government directives.

Research indicating that bureaucracies are still not sufficiently autonomous to actively oppose populist governments (Bauer, Peters, and Pierre 2021) deserves reservations, as we observed that a well-trained civil service with less political interference is more likely to form resistance to government directives. For this, the individual civil servant must be empowered in their role as a political actor so that they can assist in building

a bureaucracy more resistant to populism, contrasting with the view of the stable civil servant who aims only for stability (O'Leary 2010).

Note

1. As a robustness check, we explored whether junior officials—those with five years or less at PGFN—were less likely to resist, based on the assumption that job insecurity might suppress dissent. Results, presented in Appendix 2, show no statistically significant difference between junior and senior officials, likely due to limited statistical power and Brazil's strong civil service protections, even during probation.

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Notes on contributors

José Renato Fragoso Lobo holds a master's degree in public administration from the Brazilian School of Public and Business Administration (Fundação Getúlio Vargas – FGV).

Maiara Marinho holds a Ph.D. in Public Administration from the Brazilian School of Public and Business Administration (Fundação Getúlio Vargas – FGV). She researches issues related to bureaucracies, administrative burdens, citizen-state relationships, AI, algorithms, scarcity, poverty, and political psychology.

Alketa Peci is a Full Professor at the Brazilian School of Public and Business Administration (Fundação Getúlio Vargas – FGV). Her research interests relate to the study of bureaucracy and its major transformations, focusing on autonomous bureaucracies as Independent Regulatory Agencies (IRAs) and Audit Offices; on bureaucratic representation; public-private/nonprofit partnerships, and the adoption of better regulation reforms. Her recent work has been published in Public Administration Review, Regulation & Governance, Perspectives on Public Management and Governance, and Public Management Review.

João V. Guedes-Neto is Assistant Professor at the Brazilian School of Public and Business Administration (Fundação Getúlio Vargas – FGV). He investigates intergroup relations, coordination problems, and policy implementation. His recent work has been published in Comparative Political Studies, Party Politics, Electoral Studies, Representation, and Political Studies Review. He is the co-organizer of "Inside Brazilian Bureaucracy: Politics and Policy Implementation in Brazilian States" (Routledge) and co-author of "Bureaucratic Resistance in Times of Democratic Backsliding" (Cambridge University Press).

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Appendices

Appendix 1: Descriptive statistics

Table A1. Descriptive statistics of covariates.

Covariates	Number of observations
Gender	Male (*N* = 329; 59.1%)
	Female (*N* = 228; 40.9%)
Age	18–31 years old (*N* = 19; 3.4%)
	32–45 years old (*N* = 358; 64.3%)
	46–59 years old (*N* = 170; 30.5%)
	60–75 years old (*N* = 10; 1.8%)
Education	College (*N* = 82; 14.7%)
	Professional Specialization (*N* = 323; 58.0%)
	MA or Ph.D. (*N* = 152; 27.3%)
Experience	0–5 years (*N* = 50; 9.0%)
	6–10 years (*N* = 67; 12.0%)
	11–15 years (*N* = 247; 44.3%)
	16–20 years (*N* = 96; 17.2%)
	21–25 years (*N* = 70; 12.6%)
	25 years or more (*N* = 27; 4.8%)
Supervisor	Commissioned (*N* = 132; 23.7%)
	Not commissioned (*N* = 425; 76.3%)
Autonomy	Avg. for supervisors = 8,32 (DP = 1.87)
	Avg. for non-supervisors = 7,84 (DP = 1.94)

Table A2. Balance test.

Covariates	x^2 (*p*-value)	Control (*N* = 287)	Treatment (*N* = 270)
Gender	0,069 (0,793)	Female (*N* = 119)	Female (*N* = 109)
Experience	0,925 (0,968)	0–5 years (*N* = 24)	0–5 years (*N* = 26)
		6–10 years (*N* = 36)	6–10 years (*N* = 31)
		11–15 years (*N* = 131)	11–15 years (*N* = 116)
		16–20 years (*N* = 47)	16–20 years (*N* = 49)
		21–25 years (*N* = 35)	21–25 years (*N* = 35)
		25 years or more (*N* = 14)	25 years or more (*N* = 13)
Age	0,715 (0,870)	18–31 years old (*N* = 8)	18–31 years old (*N* = 11)
		32–45 years old (*N* = 186)	32–45 years old (*N* = 172)
		46–59 years old (*N* = 88)	46–59 years old (*N* = 82)
		60–75 years old (*N* = 5)	60–75 years old (*N* = 5)
Education	0,295 (0,861)	College (*N* = 44)	College (*N* = 38)
		Professional Specialization (*N* = 167)	Professional Specialization (*N* = 156)
		MA or Ph.D. (*N* = 76)	MA or Ph.D. (*N* = 76)
Supervisor	0,361 (0,548)	Commissioned (*N* = 65)	Commissioned (*N* = 67)
		Not Commissioned (*N* = 222)	Not Commissioned (*N* = 203)

Appendix 2: Robustness check

We conducted a robustness check to explore whether junior treasury attorneys – those with less than five years of experience at the PGFN – are less likely to shirk or sabotage than their more experienced counterparts. This test relates to the hypothesis that job insecurity, particularly during the probationary period (the first three years of public service in Brazil), may discourage resistance behaviour due to the heightened risk of dismissal.

While our original survey did not include a discrete question identifying probationary status (i.e. whether respondents were within their first three years of service), it did include a categorical measure of time at the institution. The lowest available category was "0–5 years," encompassing both probationary and early-tenured officials. Only 50 respondents fell into this category, constituting approximately 9% of the total sample.

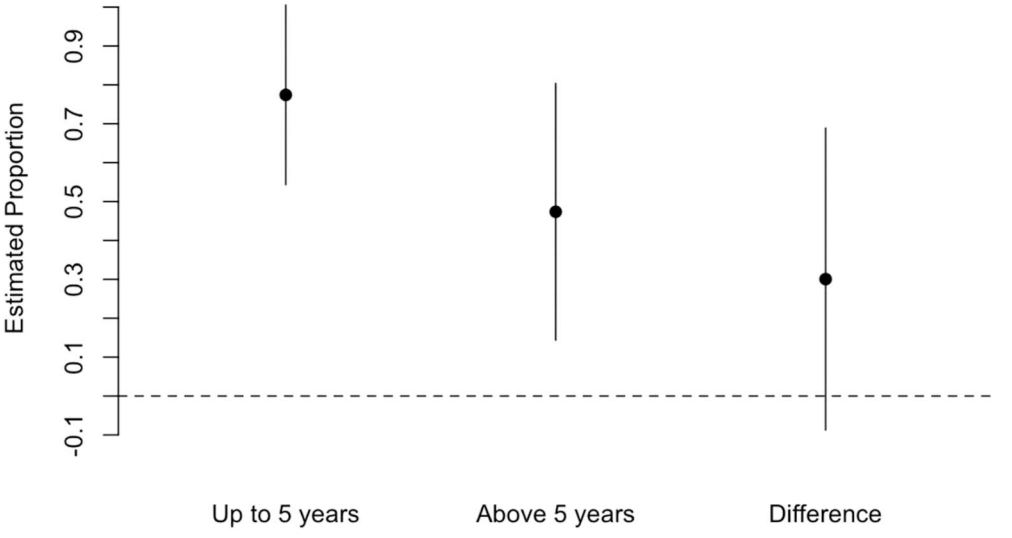


Figure A1. Treatment effects by time of service.

Appendix 2 Figure 1 displays the average estimated proportion of respondents indicating willingness to shirk under treatment conditions, with 95% confidence intervals, for two groups: (1) those with up to five years of service and (2) those with more than five years. The third point represents the estimated difference in treatment effects between the two groups.

As shown, while respondents with five years or less at PGFN report slightly higher willingness to shirk (point estimate ≈ 0.7) than their more experienced peers (≈ 0.5), the difference is not statistically significant. Confidence intervals are wide and overlapping, reflecting limited statistical power due to the small subsample size.

We emphasize that this finding should be interpreted with caution. It does not provide clear evidence against our theoretical framework, nor does it lend strong support to the proposed mechanism of job insecurity deterring resistance. Rather, it highlights the limits of measurement precision in small subsamples and the potential mismatch between available survey categories and institutional definitions of probation.

This additional analysis complements our broader modelling strategy, where H2 tests the impact of commissioned positions (rather than tenure) as a mechanism of political control. While probationary status may theoretically influence risk sensitivity, Brazil's civil service protections render dismissals extremely rare, even during illiberal administrations. As such, the practical distinction between early-career and tenured officials may be less consequential for resistance behaviour than proximity to political authority via supervisory roles.